ASSEMBLY POLLS 2022

UTTARAKHAND

CHARITY ENDS AT HOME

Hemmed in by rivals within the Congress, the former CM is forced to fight a tough election from a BJP bastion

ANILESH S. MAHAJAN

On January 30, while out trying to connect with his voters, Congress leader Harish Rawat landed up at a kabaddi court in Bindukhatta village. The 73-year-old playfully entered the arena for a few minutes of friendly jousting, even scored a point or two. His real game will need to be less desultory, though. Bindukhatta, in the Terai section of Uttarakhand's Nainital district, comes under Lalkuan constituency, and it's not an electoral battlefield of choice. Rawat was slated to contest from Ramnagar next door, a relatively easier seat, but lost out to...shall we say, inner-party democracy? Now, the former CM has been paradropped right into an enemy fastness, and he'll be up against the BJP's Mohan Singh Bisht. A bit like blundering perilously into the other half of the kabaddi court—love may be hard to find on February 14, voting day.

Love is a scarce commodity even within the Congress camp. If Uttarakhand's electoral politics is largely bipolar, the Grand Old Party is itself a bipolar entity within it. Harish Rawat, despite being the tallest party leader in the state, forms only one axis. The other is Pritam Singh, who is a decade younger, is state LoP and perhaps Rawat's fiercest opponent. Considered close to Rahul Gandhi, Pritam has enjoyed a rising graph in recent years but has yet to demonstrate that he can single-handedly take the party to electoral victory. Rawat returned to Uttarakhand politics recently after relinquishing charge of Punjab. But things haven't gone his way in his home state. Denied a free hand in candidate selection, he sulked, but earned only a minor sop—being made head of the campaign, not the party's CM face.

Being unable to insist on his own seat is a sign of how the equations have changed for Rawat. What made him withdraw from Ramnagar was a counter-claim from state Congress working president Ranjit Rawat—a Pritam acolyte. The latter was eventually nominated from Salt constituency in Almora district, but by then Harish had relented and shifted to Lalkuan. But his headache migrated with him. Sandhya Dalakoti, whom Rawat had replaced in Lalkuan, went right ahead and filed her nomination too as an Independent. She reportedly has Pritam's backing. Lalkuan is just one of the 29 seats where rebel candidates threaten to mar the Congress's chances. Harish has chosen to grin and bear it—calling himself "a true soldier of the party"—but his loyalists concede that for a leader nursing chief ministerial ambition, being hemmed in thus has dented his image.

For all this, some Congress leaders in Delhi believe it will be hard for the BJP to buck the strong anti-incumbency. The Congress had only 11 seats in the outgoing 70-member assembly but bagged 34 per cent of the vote share. The BJP got 57 seats with a hefty 47 per cent vote share. That may well be trimmed, but one worry for the Congress is whether it can hold on to the 14 per cent Muslim vote, for which there are multiple contenders this time. The BSP, SP and Asaduddin Owaisi's AIMIM have fielded 18 Muslim candidates, including in Haridwar (Rural) where Rawat's daughter Anupama is in the fray. Muslims are largely concentrated in Haridwar district, besides a sprinkling in Udham Singh Nagar and pockets of Nainital and Dehradun. The BSP commands some influence in Haridwar district and the Dalit-Muslim combination got it 7 per cent of the total votes in 2017, mostly in Haridwar, though without any seat to show for it. What the Congress has going for it, besides the BJP's none-too-enthusing record in governance, is a matching graph of rebellion on the other side. The return of former Congressmen like Harak Rawat—whose ex-beauty queen daughter-in-law Anukriti Gusain has been fielded from Lansdowne—only deepens the schisms in the Congress though. ■



A HOUSE DIVIDED
Harish Rawat with party leaders in Dehradun

ANI